

Workplace Hazardous Materials Information System (WHMIS)

WHMIS: Labels

Canada has aligned the Workplace Hazardous Materials Information System, or WHMIS, with the Globally Harmonized System of Classification and Labelling of Chemicals, or GHS. This lesson discusses the WHMIS 2015 supplier requirements under federal legislation, the Hazardous Products Act, or HPA, and the Hazardous Products Regulations, or HPR.

Health Canada is the government body responsible for the overall WHMIS supplier-related laws. It is to be noted that WHMIS is also regulated in the workplace by the provincial, territorial, and federal (for federally regulated workplaces) governments through their occupational health and safety legislation. While these jurisdictions mostly based their WHMIS regulations on a common model, small variations between jurisdictions may exist regarding WHMIS 2015.

Suppliers and employers must use and follow the WHMIS 2015 requirements for labels and safety data sheets, also called SDSs, for hazardous products sold, distributed, or imported in Canada

Now, let's go over which products require a WHMIS 2015 label.

In Canada, WHMIS legislation requires that any products used in the workplace that meet the criteria to be classified as hazardous products must be labelled.

Labels are the first alert to the user as to the major hazards associated with a certain product. They outline the basic precautions the user needs to take in order to minimize any risks.

In most cases, suppliers are responsible for labelling the hazardous products they provide to customers. Labels should be affixed to, printed, or written on, or attached to the hazardous product or container and must remain legible .

Employers are responsible for making sure that hazardous products that come into the workplace are labelled and must be prepared to apply a workplace label when appropriate.

There are two main types of WHMIS labels: supplier labels and workplace labels.

Suppliers of hazardous products are required to apply labels that meet HPR requirements. If the hazardous product is always used in the container with the supplier label, no other label is required.

A workplace label is required when a hazardous product is produced or used in the workplace, decanted, transferred or poured into another container, or when a supplier label becomes lost or unreadable.

There are two situations when a workplace label is not necessary. One is when a hazardous product is poured into a container and is going to be used immediately, or when a product is "under the control of the person who decanted it". For example, when the person who poured the product into another container will be the only person who will use it, and the product will only be used during one shift, a full workplace label may not be required. However, the container must still be identified with the product identifier or name. When the product is not used right away or if more than one person will be in control of the product, a full workplace label is required. Note that a company may have specific rules about labelling containers that exceed the WHMIS requirements, as well as your local provincial or territorial jurisdiction.

The supplier is required to include certain information on the label. Supplier labels must be in both official languages of Canada, English and French. Labels may have versions with both languages, or be separated into two labels, but they must both be available. Providing a supplier label in just English or French would not be in compliance.

The supplier label must include the following information:

- **Product identifier—the name, such as the brand, chemical, commonly-used, generic, or trade name, of the hazardous product.**

- **Initial supplier identifier, which means the name, address, and telephone number of either the Canadian manufacturer or the Canadian importer .**
- **Pictogram, which is a hazard symbol within a red "square set on one of its points".**
- **Signal word, which is a word used to alert the reader to a potential hazard and to indicate the severity of the hazard.**
- **Hazard statement, which is a standardized phrase that describes the nature of the hazard posed by a hazardous product.**
- **Precautionary statement, which are standardized phrases that describe measures to be taken to minimize or prevent adverse effects resulting from exposure or improper handling or storage of a hazardous product.**

Finally, supplemental label information may be depending on the classification of the product. For example, the label for a mixture containing ingredients with unknown toxicity in amounts higher than or equal to one percent must include a statement indicating the percent of the ingredient or ingredients with unknown toxicity. Labels may also include supplementary information about precautionary actions, hazards not yet included in the GHS, physical state, or route of exposure. This information must not contradict or detract from the standardized information.

Another thing you need to know about labels is their signal words.

A signal word is a prompt that alerts you to the degree or level of hazard of the product. There are only two signal words used: "Danger" or "Warning". "Danger" is used for high-risk hazards, while "Warning" is used for less severe hazards. If a signal word is assigned to a hazard class and category, it must be shown on the label, and listed in Section 2 , the Hazards Identification section, of the SDS. Some hazard classes or categories do not have a signal word assigned to them.

Another piece of information labels may contain is a hazard statement.

Each hazard class and category is assigned a hazard statement, which is a brief, standardized sentence that tells you more about the exact hazard related to the product. The statement is short, but describes the most significant hazards of the product.

Examples of hazard statements are:

- Extremely flammable gas.
- Contains gas under pressure; may explode if heated.
- Fatal if inhaled.
- Causes eye irritation.
- May cause cancer.

The wording of the hazard statement helps describe the degree of the hazard. For example: "May cause cancer" is more hazardous than "Suspected of causing cancer".

Labels may also include precautionary statements. These provide advice on how to minimize or prevent adverse effects resulting from exposure to a hazardous product or resulting from improper storage or handling of a hazardous product. These statements can include instructions about storage, handling, first aid, personal protective equipment, and emergency measures. Similar to hazard statements, the wording of precautionary statements is standardized and harmonized.

There are five types of precautionary statements: general, prevention, and response, including first aid treatment, storage, and disposal. Examples of precautionary statements are:

- Keep container tightly closed.
- Wear protective clothing.
- If exposed or concerned: Get medical advice/attention.
- Fight fire remotely due to the risk of explosion.
- Protect from sunlight.

Precautionary statements are consistent with the degree of the hazard associated with the product.

When reading and understanding labels, you may see the slash symbol or the "dot-dot-dot," an ellipsis. The use of the slash or the dots is intended as instructions to the supplier to help in preparing the label and SDS.

For example , the guidance material from GHS lists the following precautionary statement "Wear protective gloves/protective clothing/eye protection/face protection." The slash means the supplier is to specify the appropriate type of equipment according to their knowledge of the product and how it is used. So, for example, this statement could appear as: "Wear protective gloves and eye protection", or "Wear protective gloves", or "Wear protective gloves, protective clothing, eye protection, and face protection".

Another example is "Do not subject to grinding/shock/friction/...". In this case, the supplier must specify the applicable rough handling circumstance to avoid, such as grinding, shock and/or friction, and the dots (...) mean they should consider other types of rough handling that should be mentioned.

Another helpful thing to know is what supplier labels look like. As a general rule, there is no set format for a supplier label, apart from the fact that it must be in English and French. As mentioned, you can choose to use one label with both languages, or two labels, one in English and one in French. It's up to you, as long as both languages are available on the product.

Labels will require the following:

- the pictogram, signal word, and hazard statement are to be grouped together,**
- to be clearly and prominently displayed on the container,**
- to be easy to read, for example, you can read it easily without any help (except corrective glasses), and**
- to be in contrast with other information on the product or container.**

Here's an example of a bilingual label :

Suppliers are required to update labels when they become aware of any "significant new data". This means that if new evidence arises that affects the way people should protect themselves against hazards when using a product, the label must be updated. This usually happens when the classification changes based on newly found health risks. Labels will be required to be updated within 180 days of the supplier being aware of the new information in writing .

It is anticipated that employers will be required to update the existing labels or the information on the containers as soon as significant new information is provided by the supplier. Watch for confirmations, updates, or changes to WHMIS regulations applicable in your jurisdiction.

Workplace labels also require certain information, including:

- **The product name, matching the product name on the SDS.**
- **Safe handling precautions, which may include pictograms or other supplier label information.**
- **A reference to the SDS, if available.**

You can find applicable workplace label requirements in the WHMIS legislation for your province or territory, or in the Canada Labour Code if you work in a federally regulated workplace. It's always best to confirm the exact requirements within your jurisdiction.

Now, there are some variations in labels that are allowed. A WHMIS label can be in the form of a mark, sign, stamp, sticker, seal, ticket, tag, or wrapper. It can also be attached, imprinted, stenciled, or embossed on the hazardous product or its container. Workers must be trained to identify these alternate systems if they are used in the workplace.

Variations on the supplier label apply in specific situations such as:

- **Bulk shipments. There is a labelling exemption for products sold without packaging.**
- **Products containing 100 milliliters or less. These are exempt from the requirement to have precautionary or hazard statements on the label.**

- **Products containing three milliliters or less. Because of their small size, the label could interfere with normal use of the product. So, the product would be required to have a label that's durable and legible for transport and storage purposes, but that may be removed during use.**
- **Because of the convenient size, a fold-out or accordion-style label is allowed if there is not enough space on the product to provide a label that meets the legibility requirements of the HPR**

Legislation also provides specific guidance on how hazardous products packaged in multiple containers should be labelled.

If a hazardous product is packaged in more than one container, each container must be fully labelled .

As you walk away from this lesson, keep these things in mind as a worker when using hazardous products:

- **Always check to see if there is a label on the product before you use it.**
- **Read, understand, and follow the instructions on the label and SDS. Follow any additional education, instructions, and training provided by your employer.**
- **Ask your supervisor if you are not sure about how to use or store a product.**
- **Ask for a new label when the old one cannot be seen or read properly.**
- **Do not use a product that is not labelled or has an unreadable label. Ask your supervisor for help or to replace the label in question.**

Finally, don't be ignorant when it comes to the hazardous chemicals your workplace uses, or that you may come into contact with. By understanding Canada's requirements on labeling hazardous products, you can make sure you're fully aware of how to protect yourself and prioritize the health and wellbeing of everyone in your organization.